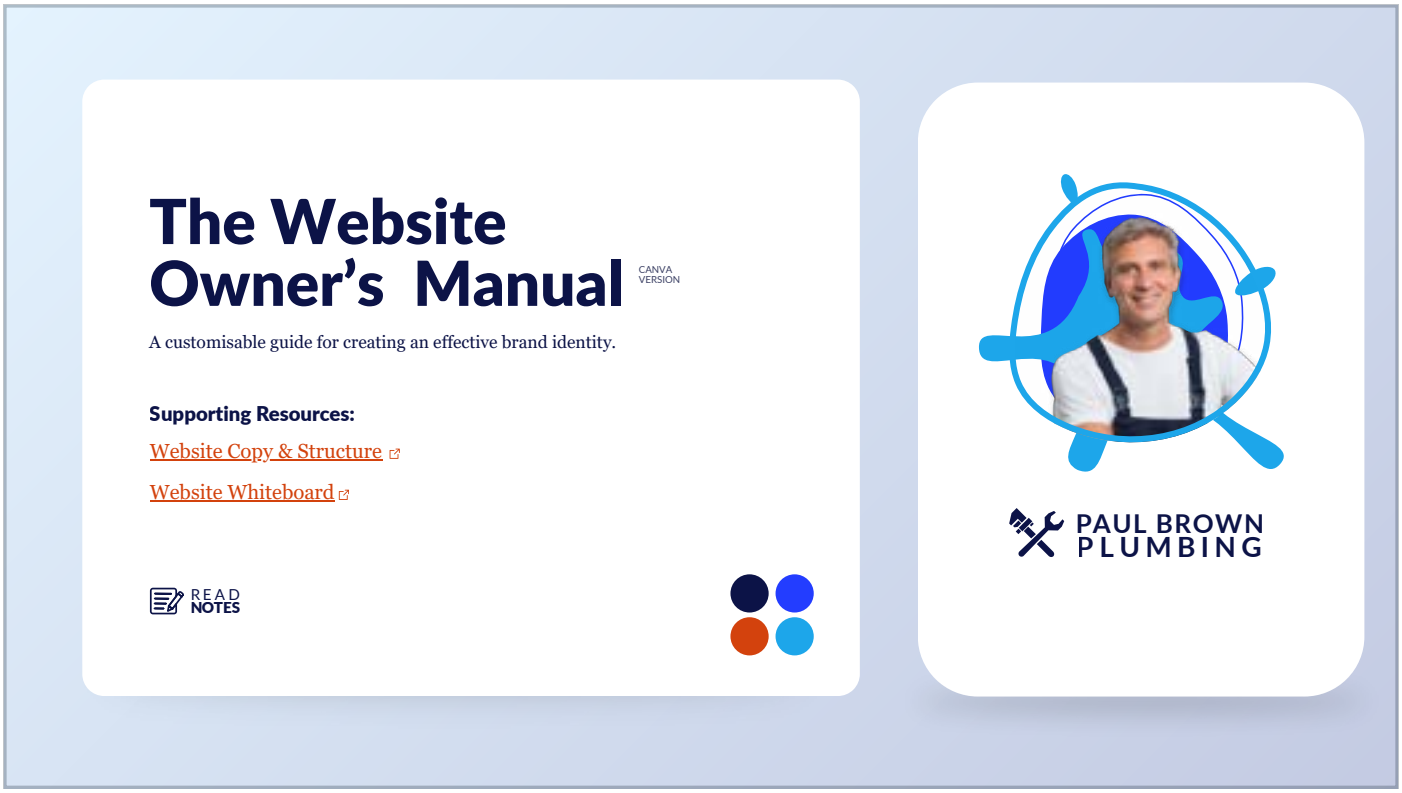


The Website Owner's Manual is platform-agnostic.

Canva is used because:

1. It saves to PTTX or PDF for use with PowerPoint or LibreOffice.

2. Its real-time collaboration and commenting system allows multiple users to edit simultaneously.

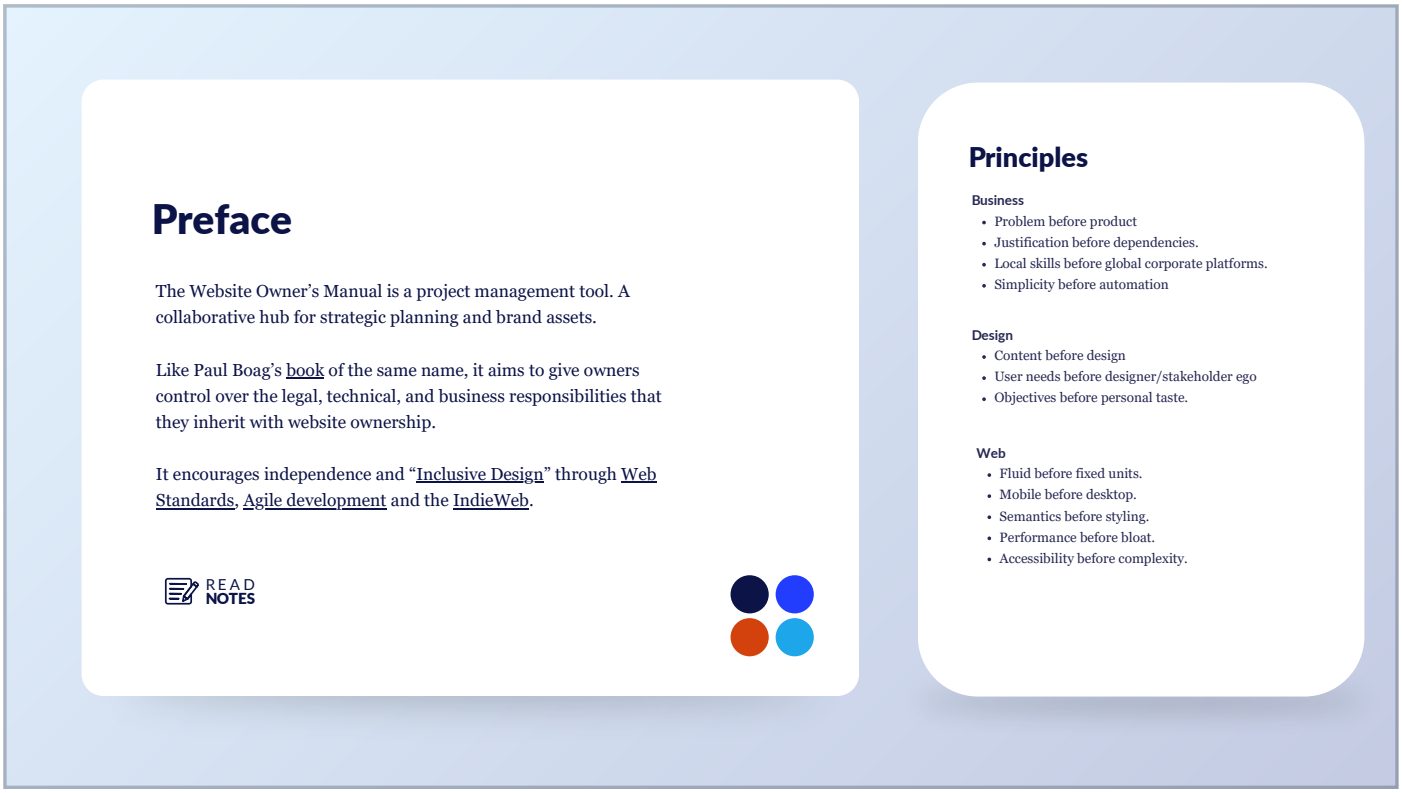
3. Its whiteboard allows one place to store assets and experiment.

4. It's popular with small businesses (over 230 million monthly active users).

5. You get one month's free access to the pro version with vast stock resources.

6. Advanced presentation tools like audience Q&A, remote control, and drawing on slides.

As image editing software, it's limited compared to Figma, Adobe, or Canvas's own Affinity Studio, but professional collaborators can add their work to Canva.



NOTES

Designers can use this to remind clients of the unique features of the web, their responsibilities, and head off potential friction.

For example:

1. It makes it easier to see what and when a platform is needed, rather than picking it for them and subsequently having to justify it.

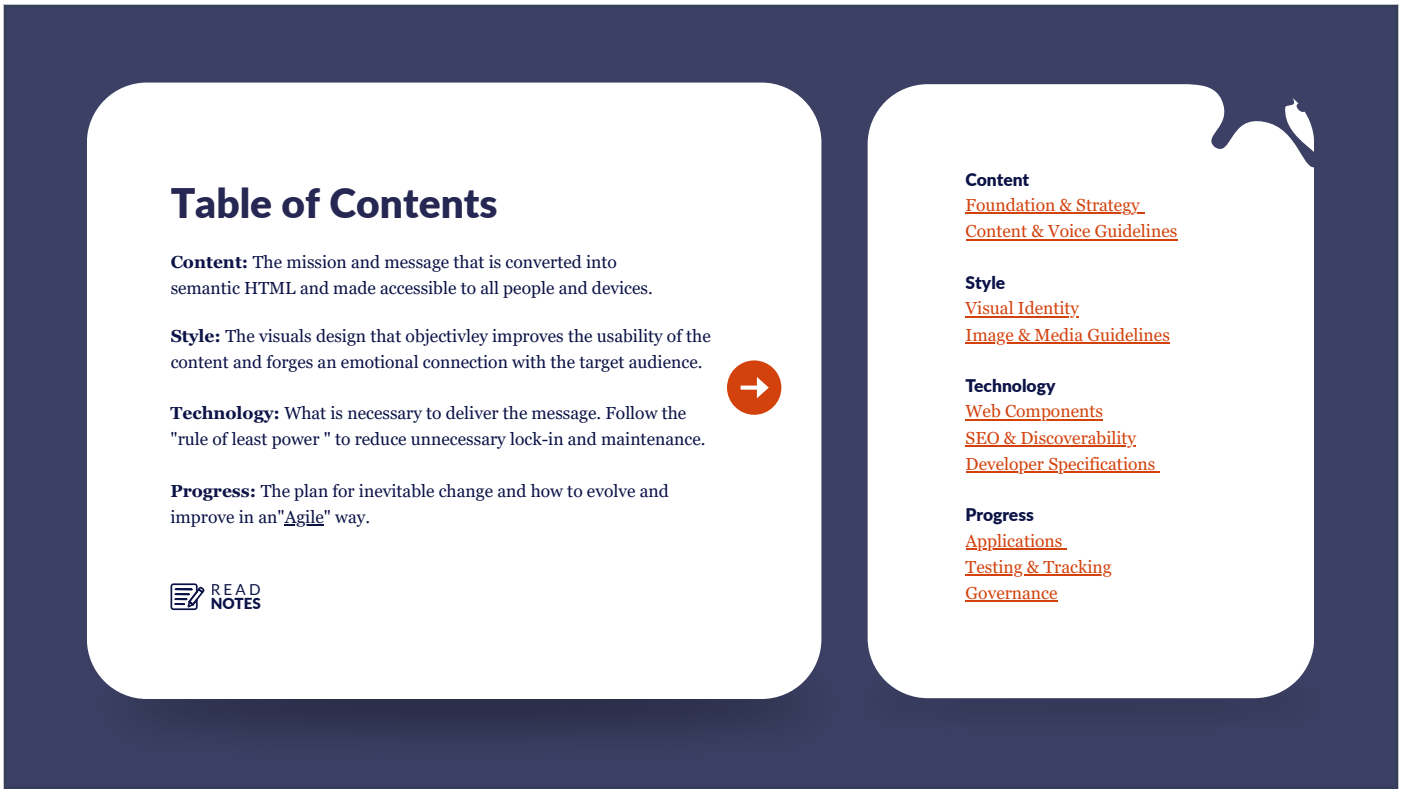
2. It provides the tools to assess other sites, avoiding telling the owner their ideas are bad and having to criticise the work of others.

3. It positions design as problem-solving to avoid the process becoming a community art project.

4. Reduces the need for torturous contracts.

Paul Boag's 2009 O'Reilly book is now available for free.

It is still relevant, but predates the general shift to Agile development processes.



The next 10 slides represent the top-level navigation.

Designers may use these to understand what a client already knows and has.

NOTES

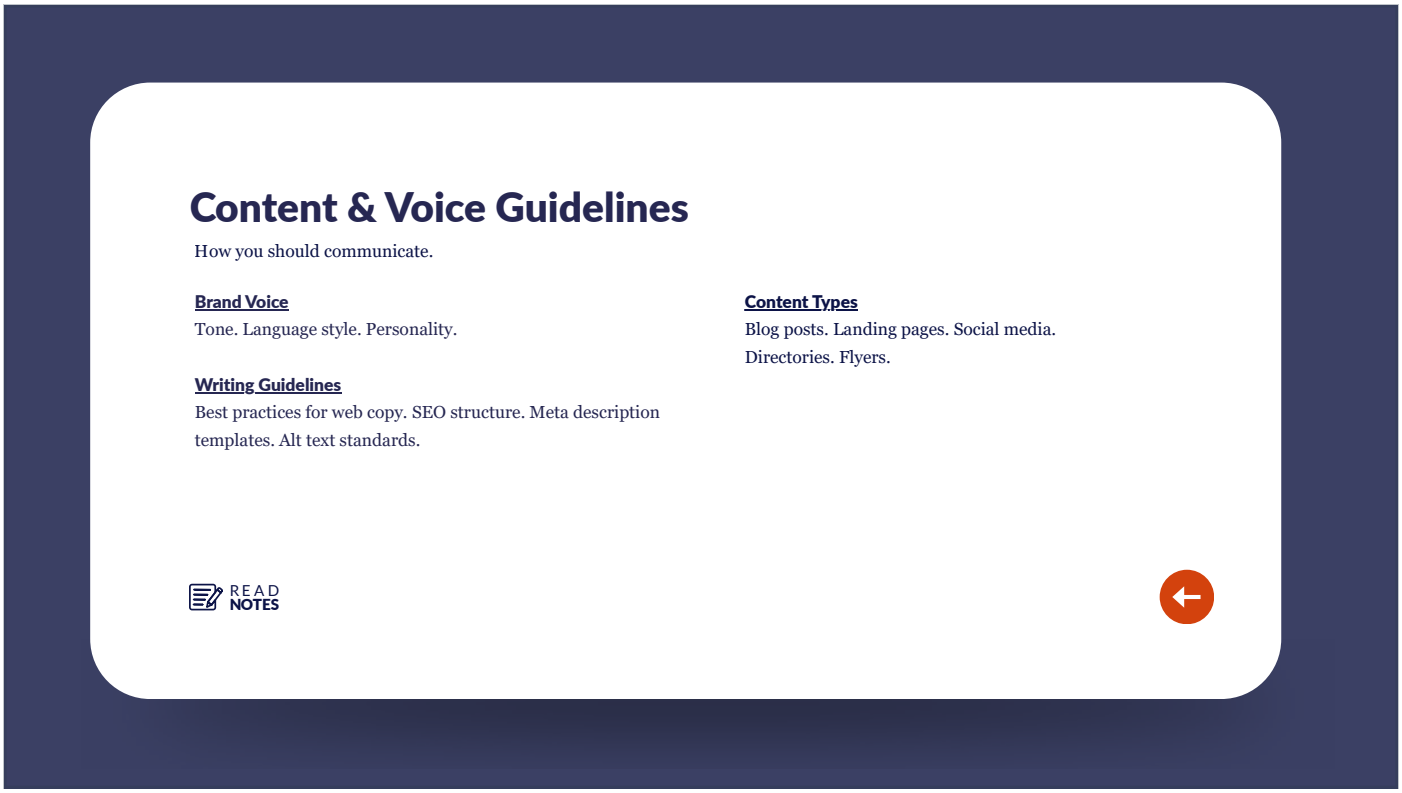
This is often the hardest part.

Creating a brand requires introspection, and many in business are people of action who employ their gut to adapt to situations.

Online, we have to define upfront a purpose and target audience to cut through the noise and avoid being for no-one in particular.

Online, customers can't meet you first, so your brand identity has to act as your "digital handshake".

On the plus side, this work can act as a useful "North Star" for general business decisions and reduce the need to compete solely on price.

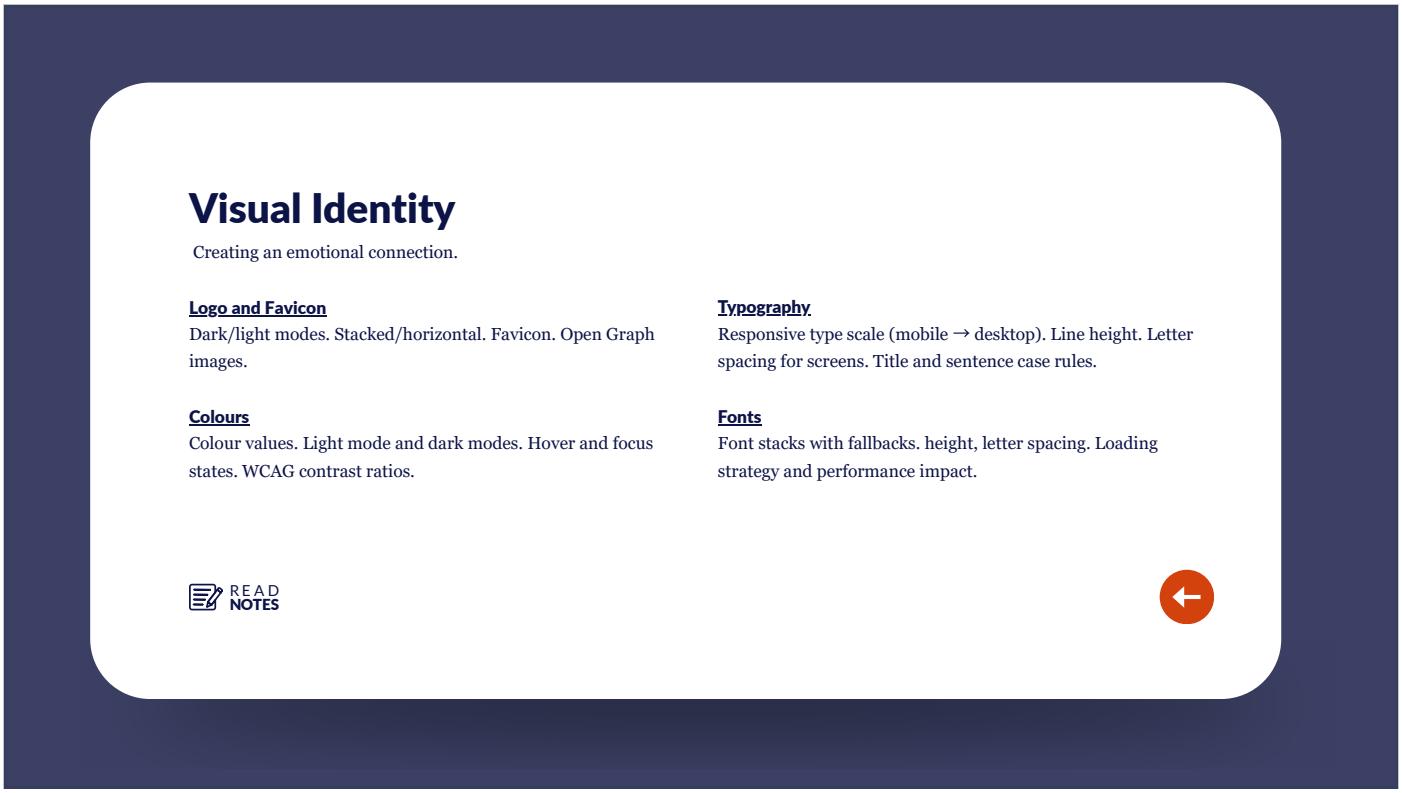


NOTES

People buy from people, so we have to cut through the impersonal nature of the web.

It's not "creative writing", but reputation control.

It tells people what they should expect in advance.



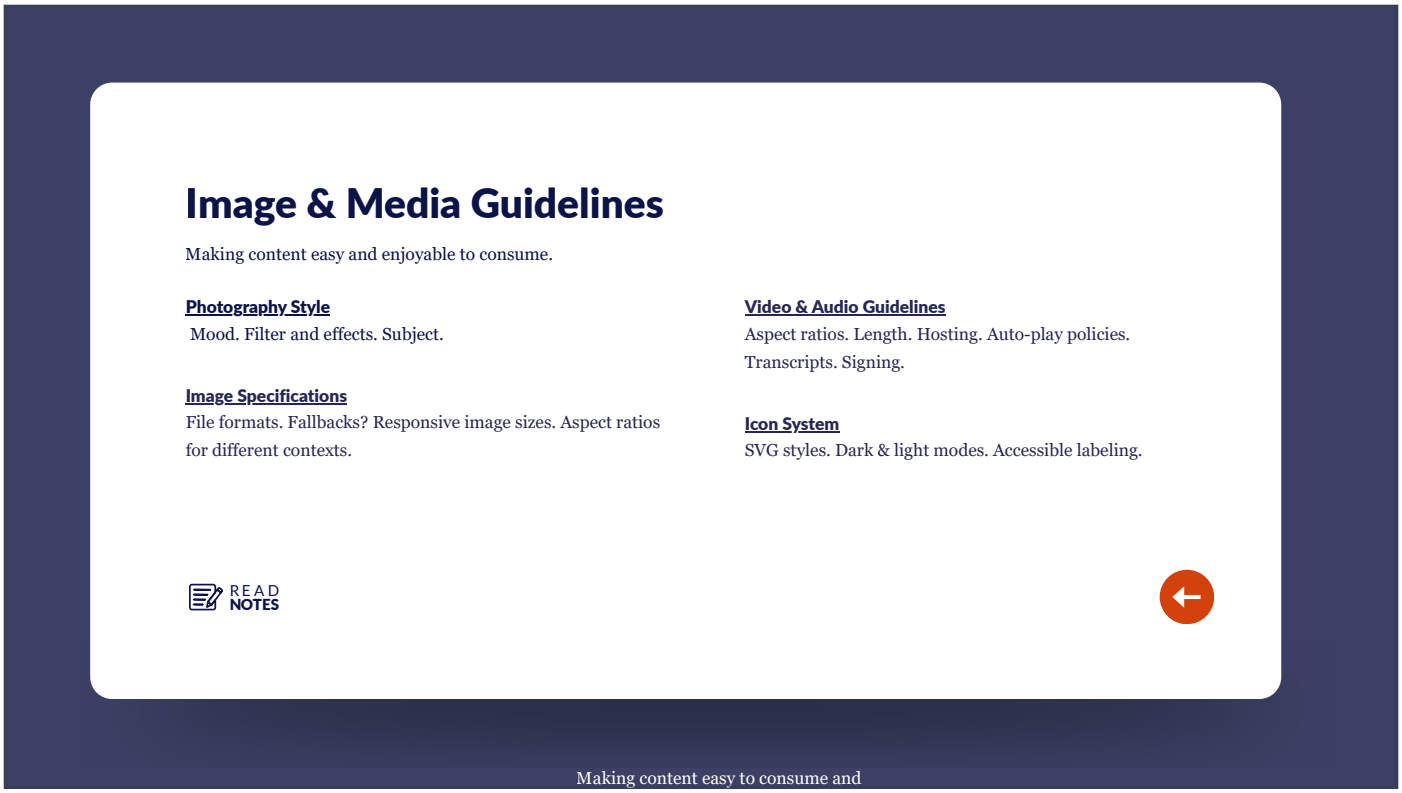
NOTE

This should be congruent with the brand's written voice and mission.

We should choose based on what objectively best represents the brand to users.

Remember that some visitors will only see or hear your written content (screen readers and search bots).

Increasingly, some will have preferences that will remove a website's styling (high-contrast themes and monochrome screens).

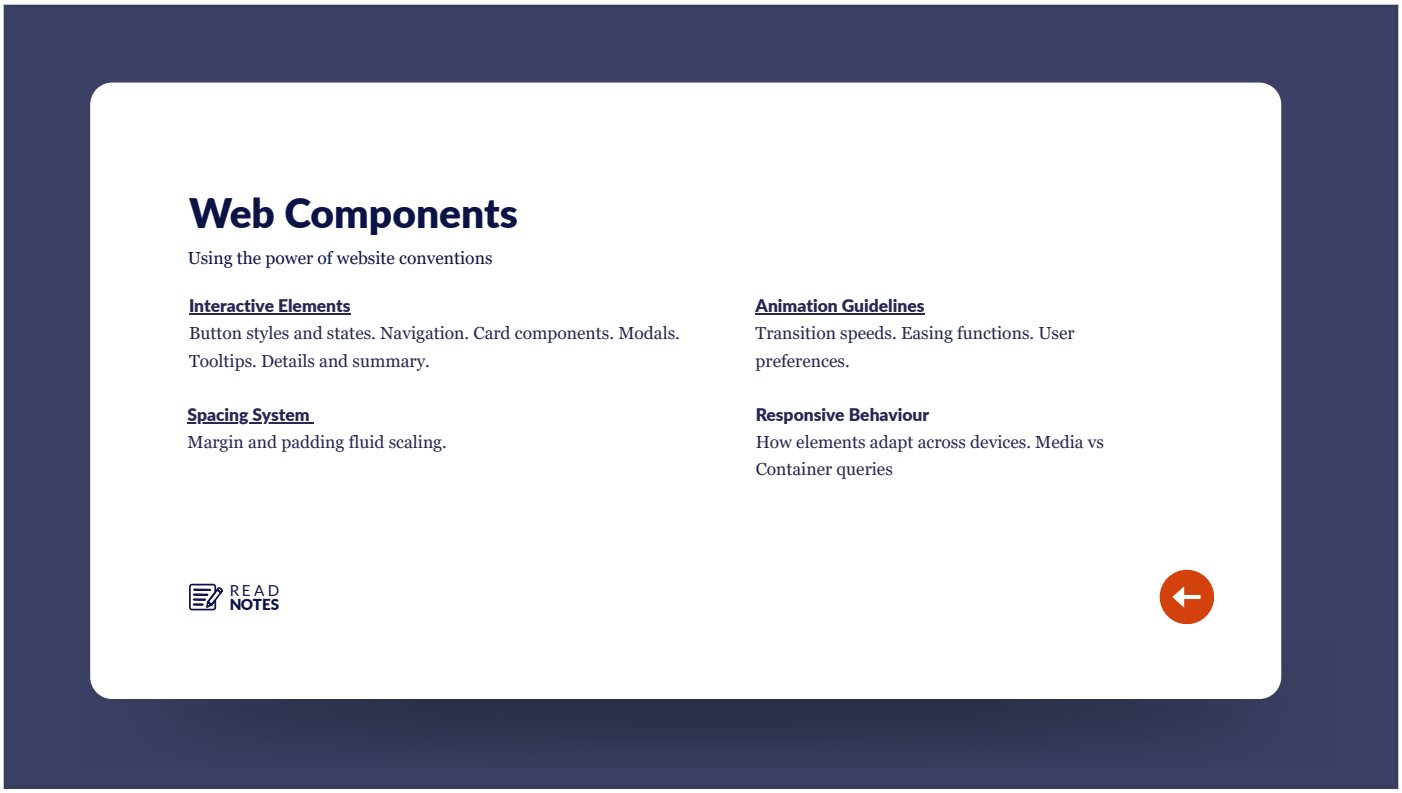


NOTES

Embedded images and media make sites interesting.

But there are performance trade-offs, accessibility barriers, and the potential for information fragmentation to consider.

We should ask: Does this media supplement the written text, or are we filling because of poor layout planning?



The web is interactive.

We need to tab, mouse-click, or finger-tap links and buttons, and we should get visual or audio feedback on our actions

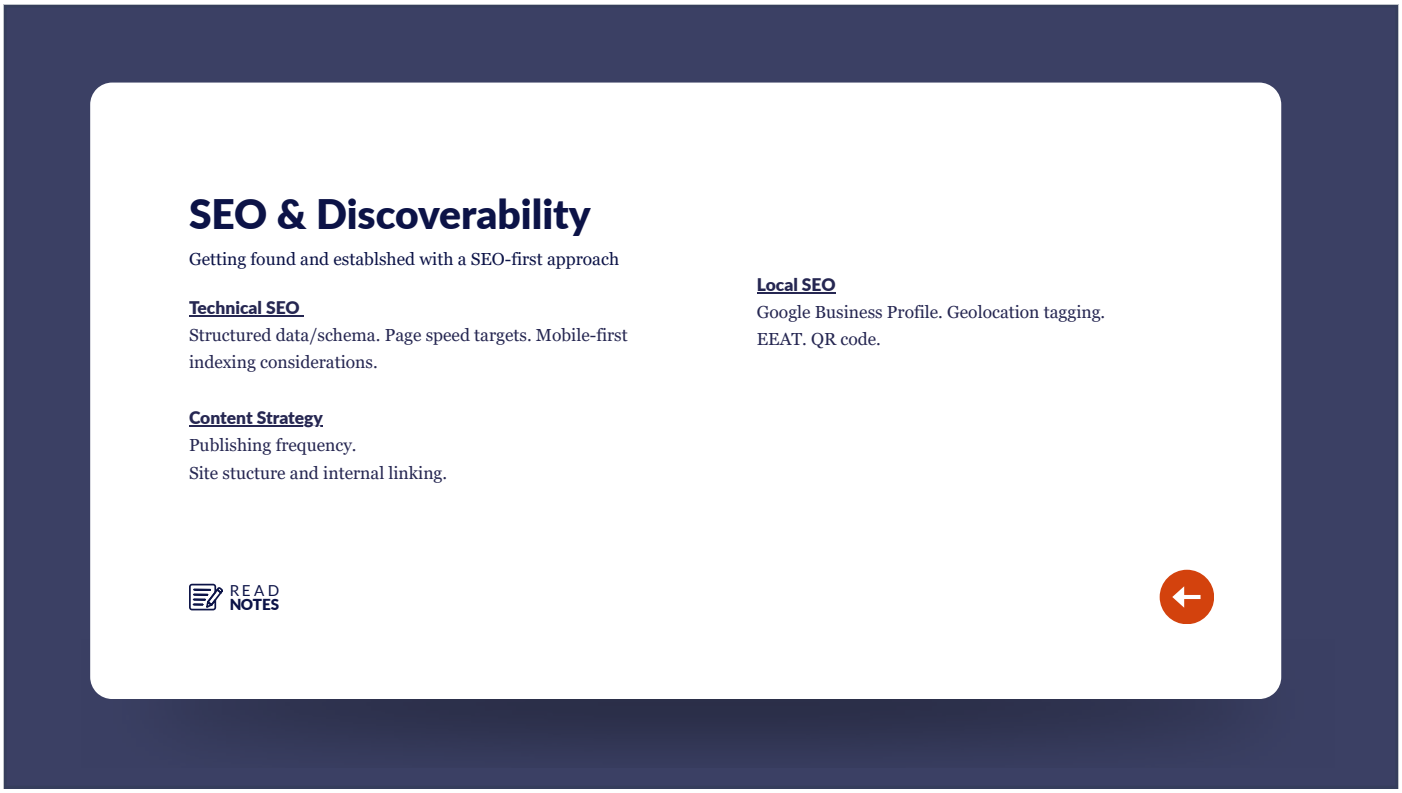
Visitors need to understand our UI and conventions are our friends in this aim.

Unfortunately, design systems have a history of breaking conventions:

1. Removing link underlines (Twitter Bootstrap V3).

2. Replacing form input titles with placeholders (Google's Material Design system).

We should avoid complexity and follow WCAG guidelines rather than blindly trust third parties even if they are used by millions.



NOTES

With well-structured semantic HTML content, SEO largely takes care of itself.

There can be gains from exploiting weaknesses in search engines, but it's risky.

For most businesses, their domain name (and the online authority it gains over time) is too valuable to throw away on tricks for short-term gains.

Developer Specifications

Code standards and policies on the tech used

Code Standards
CSS methodology. Browser support.
Accessibility requirements.

Performance
Max page weight. Core Web Vitals targets.
Image optimization standards

Maintenance Protocols
CMS guidelines. Dependency. Update schedule. Backup procedures. Security best practices.

Hosting & Infrastructure
Environment specs, CDN usage, caching strategy.

NOTES

Applications

How the brand is used across platforms

Social Media
Profile images, cover photos, post templates (per platform)

Google Business Profile
Photo requirements, post formatting.

Email
Template structure, mobile optimization

Directory and Review Listings
Profile images, cover photos, post templates (per platform)

Off-Line
Community & Sponsorship.Print & Physical Materials

NOTES

Testing & Tracking

How do we ethically measure sucess?

User Testing
Can vistors find waht they need. Are the confused about what is clickable. What is the impression of the site?

Analytics Tools
If needed, do we use privacy-first, no cookies tools like possible Analytics or Google Analytics where a visitor consent pop-up is required.

Our Privacy Policy
Cookie stance. Use of dark patterns. Hidden tracking “pixels”. Session replay tools.

READ NOTES

NOTES

Governance

Who is resposible for what

Who can update what?
Level of permissions to any CMS, Github or GitLab.
Access to the Website Owner's Guide.

Review Schedule
Quarterly audits, annual strategic reviews.

Legal
Is the website following the law and who follows changes?

Change Log
Tracking what and how?

Decision Framework
How to handle edge cases not covered in guidelines.
What happens when someone is hit by a bus?

READ NOTES